Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on John Donne's "[This is my play's last scene; here heavens appoint]"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of the controlling images' (metaphors') support of the speaker's focus in Donne's "[This is my play's last scene; here heavens appoint]" on the transition from life to death include

alliteration,
analogy,
apostrophe,
asyndeton,
connotation,
couplet,
denotation,
elision (syncope),
iambic pentameter,
imagery,
inversion,
liminality,
metaphor,
meter,
octave,
personification,
Petrarchan sonnet,
quatrain,
rhyme,
rhythm,
sestet,
sigmatism,
speaker,
spondee,
synecdoche, and
volta.

The young scholar should focus on the poem's controlling images, specifically the metaphors that are introduced in the sonnet's octave—the speaker's use of a play, a pilgrimage, a race, and the synecdochic units, span and minute, should be addressed, though the lit critter might chose to develop his or her discussion along the lines of only two of the three controlling images rather than giving equal but short shrift to all three.

The strong response will note the differences between or among the two or three metaphors discussed, perhaps recognizing the secular nature of a play in contrast to the spiritual nature of a pilgrimage.

While the poem's imagery is not confined to the controlling metaphors, the essay response should focus on the metaphors—life as a play, life as a pilgrimage, and life as a race—as introduced in the sonnet's octave.